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CUET UG

History

History of Buddhism and Jainism: Cultural Developments

Themes in Indian History (Part I) · Theme 4 · Class 12

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Aligned to the latest official syllabus · Concept-first explanations

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA History 314)	Skills the questions test
Mid-1st Millennium Ferment	Philosophical turning point, 64 sects/ schools of thought, Kutagarashala debates, fatalists (Ajivikas) and materialists (Lokayatas)	Comparative philosophy, historical context of Gangetic urbanization
Jain Philosophy & Mahavira	24 Tirthankaras, Vardhamana Mahavira, cosmic animism, strict Ahimsa, karma and ascetic penance, five vows (**Mahavratas**), monastic schisms	Doctrine recall, ascetic codes, Jain ethics and textual traditions
The Buddha & Dhamma	Siddhartha Gautama, hagiography, Four Noble Truths, Eightfold Path, **anicca**, **anatta**, **dukkha**, rejection of Vedic authority and varna	Philosophical differentiation, historical life of Buddha, Dhamma concepts
Sangha & Canonical Texts	Democratic organization of Sangha, admission of women, Mahapajapati Gotami, **Therigatha**, compilation of the **Tripitaka** (Pali canon)	Institutional history, gender in early religion, textual classification
Stupas: Sanchi & Amaravati	Relic worship, architectural anatomy (**Anda**, **Harmika**, **Yashti**, **Chhatri**, **Toranas**), why Sanchi survived (Bhopal Begums) and Amaravati fell	Architectural terminology, preservation history, colonial archaeology
Mahayana & Early Temples	Transformation into Mahayana, Bodhisattva cult, anthropomorphic imagery, early structural Hindu temples (**Garbhagriha**, **Shikhara**, **Mandapa**)	Art history, sculptural iconography, religious evolution in early India

CUET Strategy & Exam Reality

- **Core Exam Pointers:** CUET UG frequently tests exact terms: the Begums of Bhopal (**Shahjehan Begum** and **Sultan Jehan Begum**) and their financial support for John Marshall; the architectural parts of a stupa (**Anda**, **Harmika**, **Yashti**, **Chhatri**); the distinction between **Hinayana** (Theravada) and **Mahayana**; the Buddhist canon (**Vinaya**, **Sutta**, and **Abhidhamma Pitakas**); and the reasons why Amaravati stupa was ruined while Sanchi survived intact.
- **Analytical Balance:** Pay close attention to how early Buddhist art used **aniconic symbols** (an empty seat for meditation, the wheel for the first sermon at Sarnath, the stupa for the **mahaparinibbana**) before human sculptures of the Buddha emerged under Gandhara and Mathura schools.

1. The Mid-First Millennium BCE: A Global Intellectual Turning Point

The mid-first millennium BCE (c. 6th century BCE) is widely regarded by global historians as a momentous turning point in human intellectual and religious history:

- **Global Thinkers:** Thinkers across civilizations began inquiring into the nature of existence, the mysteries of death, and the cosmic order:
  - **Socrates, Plato, and Aristotle** in ancient Greece
  - **Zarathustra** (Zoroaster) in ancient Iran
  - **Kong Zi** (Confucius) and **Laozi** in ancient China
  - **Mahavira** and **Gautama Buddha** in the middle Ganga valley of India
- **The Gangetic Context:** In India, this intellectual churning coincided with the emergence of new kingdoms (the **Mahajanapadas**), rapid urbanization (the second urban revolution), expanding trade routes, and growing dissatisfaction with rigid Brahmanical sacrificial rituals (**yajnas**).
- **Sacrificial Traditions & Upanishadic Quest:** The **Rigveda** (compiled c. 1500–1000 BCE) contained hymns praising deities like Agni, Indra, and Soma for cattle, sons, and long life. By the 6th century BCE, elaborate royal sacrifices like the **Rajasuya** and **Ashvamedha** were dominated by Brahmanas. Simultaneously, the **Upanishads** began questioning the mechanical efficacy of ritual, shifting contemplation toward the ultimate reality (**Brahman**) and the individual soul (**Atman**).

Debates in the Kutagarashalas

Buddhist texts record the vibrant existence of as many as **64 distinct sects or schools of thought**:

- **Kutagarashala:** Literally "a hut with a pointed roof" or travelling mendicants' camp located in groves where travelling philosophers gathered to debate.
- **The Nature of Debates:** If a philosopher managed to convince a rival teacher of his philosophical validity, the defeated teacher and all his followers became disciples of the victor.
- **Heterodox Alternatives:**
  - **Ajivikas (Fatalists):** Founded by **Makkhali Gosala**, who taught **Niyati** (predetermined fate). According to Gosala, joy and sorrow are pre-measured like a ball of string that unwinds until it reaches its end; human effort, virtue, or penance cannot alter one's destiny.
  - **Lokayatas / Charvakas (Materialists):** Associated with **Ajita Kesakambalin**, who preached that a human being is composed of four primary elements (earth, water, fire, wind). At death, each element dissolves back into the cosmos; there is no afterlife, no soul, and no moral consequence to good or bad deeds. Sacrificial gifts to priests were merely inventions of clever men.

2. The Path of the Tirthankaras: Jain Philosophy

According to Jain tradition, **Vardhamana Mahavira** was not the founder of the religion, but the **24th Tirthankara** ("maker of the river crossing" or spiritual guide who steers souls across the river of worldly misery).

- **Predecessors:** Mahavira was preceded by 23 Tirthankaras, including **Rishabhanatha** (the first) and **Parshvanatha** (the 23rd, associated with Varanasi). Mahavira was born in Kundagrama (near Vaishali) and belonged to the Jnatrika clan of Kshatriyas.

Core Tenets of Jain Philosophy

1. **Universal Animism:** The entire universe is animate. Even stones, rocks, water droplets, and wind possess living souls (**jiva**).
2. **Strict Ahimsa (Non-violence):** Non-injury to living beings—especially humans, animals, plants, and insects—forms the central bedrock of Jain ethics. This profound principle deeply influenced Mahatma Gandhi and Indian moral philosophy.
3. **Karma and Ascetic Penance:** The cycle of birth and rebirth is shaped by karma. The accumulation of karma binds the soul to matter. The only path to annihilate existing karma and prevent new karma is through rigorous asceticism, severe penance, and complete renunciation of the material world.
4. **Monastic Imperative:** Complete liberation cannot be achieved while remaining a householder; one must take monastic vows and live an austere life.
5. **Sallekhana (Santhara):** The holy ritual death through gradual, voluntary fasting, undertaken by monks or devout laypersons when life has fulfilled its spiritual purpose. Chandragupta Maurya is traditionally believed to have undertaken Sallekhana at Shravanabelagola in Karnataka.

The Five Great Vows (Mahavratas)

Jain monks and nuns are bound to observe five cardinal vows:

1. **Ahimsa:** Abstaining from killing or harming any living creature.
2. **Satya:** Abstaining from telling lies; speaking absolute truth.
3. **Asteya:** Abstaining from stealing; not taking anything that is not freely given.
4. **Brahmacharya:** Observing strict celibacy and chastity.
5. **Aparigraha:** Abstaining from possessing property or material wealth.

The Jain Schism and Textual Transmission

Around the 3rd century BCE, following a severe famine in Magadha, Jainism split into two major traditions:

- **Digambara ("Sky-clad"):** Led by Bhadrabahu, who migrated south to Karnataka; monks abandon all clothes as a mark of absolute detachment.
- **Shvetambara ("White-clad"):** Led by Sthulabhadra, who remained in Magadha; monks wear simple unstitched white robes.
- **Jain Canonical Literature:** Originally preserved orally, the canonical texts were codified into the **Agamas** at the Council of Valabhi in Gujarat (c. 5th century CE), composed primarily in **Ardhamagadhi Prakrit**.

3. The Buddha and the Quest for Enlightenment

Siddhartha Gautama, born into the Shakya clan of Kapilavastu (in the foothills of the Himalayas, modern Nepal), was raised in luxurious seclusion.

- **The Four Great Sights:** Venturing outside the royal palace accompanied by his charioteer Channa, young Siddhartha encountered four transformative sights:
  1. An old, decrepit man bent with age
  2. A severely diseased person groaning in pain
  3. A corpse being carried to the cremation ground
  4. A peaceful, serene wandering homeless ascetic (**samana**)
- **The Great Renunciation (**Mahabhinishkramana**):** Concluding that youth, health, and life itself are transient and fraught with suffering, Siddhartha abandoned his palace, wife Yashodhara, and son Rahula at age 29 to seek absolute truth.
- **Enlightenment (**Bodhi**):** After years of experimenting with extreme self-mortification (which nearly starved him to death), Siddhartha rejected ascetic self-torture and adopted the **Middle Path**. Sitting in deep meditation under a pipal tree at Bodh Gaya, he attained supreme enlightenment and became the **Buddha** ("The Awakened One").
- **The First Sermon (**Dhammachakkappavattana**):** He delivered his first sermon at the Deer Park in **Sarnath** (near Varanasi), initiating the "Turning of the Wheel of the Law".

Core Teachings of the Buddha

The Buddha's teachings are anchored in rational psychological insight rather than metaphysical dogmatism:

- **Anicca (Transience):** The entire cosmos is constantly changing, impermanent, and in perpetual flux; nothing is static or everlasting.
- **Anatta (Soullessness):** There is no immortal, eternal, unchanging soul (**atman**) within human beings.
- **Dukkha (Sorrow):** Suffering is an intrinsic aspect of worldly existence, caused by intense craving (**tanha** or thirst) and attachment to impermanent worldly objects.
- **The Middle Path (**Majjhima Patipada**):** By following a balanced path between extreme sensual indulgence and severe ascetic self-mortification, human beings can eliminate craving.
- **Nibbana (Nirvana):** Literally "the blowing out" or extinction of the fires of greed, hatred, and ego-centric delusion, thereby ending the painful cycle of rebirth.
- **Social Equality:** The Buddha rejected the divine origin of the four-fold varna system, asserting that human worth is determined by moral conduct and compassion (**karuna**), not birth.

4. The Monastic Order: Sangha, Gender, and Canons

To preserve and propagate the Dhamma, the Buddha established the **Sangha** (monastic order of monks and nuns):

- **Bhikkhus:** Monks lived as mendicants, surviving on a single daily bowl of alms offered by lay followers. They owned only the barest essentials: three robes, a begging bowl, a razor, a needle, and a water-strainer.
- **Democratic Governance:** The Sangha was organized on democratic lines modelled after early tribal assemblies (**ganas** and **sanghas**). Decisions were reached through consensus; if consensus failed, matters were decided by voting with voting sticks (**salakas**).

The Entry of Women into the Sangha

Initially, only men were permitted into the Sangha. However, through the persistent intercession of the Buddha's favorite disciple, **Ananda**, the Buddha consented to allow women:

- **Mahapajapati Gotami:** The Buddha's foster mother and maternal aunt became the very first woman ordained as a **bhikkhuni** (Buddhist nun).
- **Therigatha:** An extraordinary collection of verses included within the **Khuddaka Nikaya** of the **Sutta Pitaka**. Composed by senior nuns (**theris**), these poems provide unparalleled first-person historical insights into women's spiritual strivings, intellectual brilliance, and triumph over patriarchal social constraints.
- **Social Composition of the Sangha:** Once inside the Sangha, all previous social identities were shed—kings, wealthy merchants (**gahapatis**), artisans, and low-born untouchables all became equal brothers (**bhikkhus**) and sisters (**bhikkhunis**).

Compilation of the Buddhist Canon: The Tripitaka

Following the **Mahaparinibbana** (passing away) of the Buddha at Kusinara (c. 486 BCE), his senior disciples convened the **First Buddhist Council** at Rajagriha under the patronage of King Ajatashatru. The teachings were codified into three great canonical baskets (**Tripitaka**), preserved in the vernacular **Pali** language:

Basket / Text	Recited / Led By	Content & Theological Scope
Vinaya Pitaka	Upali	Rules and disciplinary regulations governing the daily conduct of monks and nuns in the Sangha, penances for transgressions, and monastic etiquette.
Sutta Pitaka	Ananda	The core philosophical discourses, dialogues, and sermons delivered by the Buddha, including parables, moral stories, and the famous **Dhammapada**.
Abhidhamma Pitaka	Third Council (Pataliputra)	Advanced philosophical, scholastic, and psychological analysis of the teachings, systematizing doctrines on perception, consciousness, and metaphysics.
Jatakas	Part of Sutta Pitaka	547 popular folk tales depicting the previous virtuous lives of the Bodhisatta in animal and human forms, illustrating perfections (**paramitas**).

Basket / Text	Recited / Led By	Content & Theological Scope
Dipavamsa & Mahavamsa	Sri Lankan Chronicles	Pali historical chronicles detailing the transmission of Buddhism to Sri Lanka by Ashoka's children Mahendra and Sanghamitta.

5. Sacred Geography and Stupa Architecture

From early times, holy places associated with sacred spirits (**chaityas**) existed across the subcontinent. The Buddha sanctified four paramount pilgrimage locations:

1. **Lumbini:** The sacred grove where Siddhartha was born.
2. **Bodh Gaya:** The sacred spot beneath the Bodhi tree where he attained supreme enlightenment.
3. **Sarnath:** The deer park where he preached his first sermon (**Dhammachakkappavattana**).
4. **Kusinara (Kushinagar):** The site where he attained **Mahaparinibbana**.

Why Were Stupas Built?

According to the **Mahaparinibbana Sutta**, as the Buddha lay dying, Ananda inquired what should be done with his mortal remains. The Buddha instructed that a stupa (**thupa**) should be erected at crossroads over his bodily relics:

- **Relic Distribution:** Following his cremation, his bodily relics (bones, teeth, ashes) were partitioned into eight portions among contemporary rulers (including Ajatashatru of Magadha and the Licchavis of Vaishali) who built mounds over them.
- **Ashoka's Imperial Dispersion:** In the 3rd century BCE, the Mauryan Emperor **Ashoka** distributed portions of the Buddha's relics to every important town, ordering the construction of stupas (including the **Dharmarajika stupa** at Sarnath and the core brick stupa at Sanchi).

Anatomical Structure of a Classical Stupa



Figure 1: Figure 1: Architectural Anatomy & Cultural Symbolism of the Classical Buddhist Stupa (Anda, Harmika, Yashti, Chhatri, and Toranas).

A classical Buddhist stupa evolved from a simple semi-circular mound of earth into an intricate cosmic architectural monument:

- **Anda:** The massive semi-circular earthen and stone hemispherical dome symbolizing the celestial dome of the cosmos and the mortal containment of sacred relics.
- **Harmika:** A square balcony-like railing perched atop the crest of the Anda, revered as the sacred abode of the gods (**devaloka**).
- **Yashti:** A central vertical mast projecting upwards from the Harmika, representing the cosmic axis mundi connecting earth and heaven.
- **Chhatri (Umbrella):** A tiered canopy of triple stone umbrellas crowning the Yashti, symbolizing the Three Jewels (**Triratna**: Buddha, Dhamma, Sangha) and universal spiritual sovereignty.
- **Pradakshina-patha:** An open circular circumambulatory walkway surrounding the base of the Anda, enclosed by a perimeter stone railing. Devotees circumambulated the stupa clockwise, keeping the mound on their right shoulder.
- **Vedika:** The massive perimeter stone balustrade or railing separating sacred interior space from the mundane outside world, constructed imitating wooden fences with upright posts (**thabha**), horizontal crossbars (**suci**), and copings (**ushnisha**).
- **Toranas:** Four monumental stone gateways positioned at the cardinal directions (North, South, East, West), intricately carved with narrative bas-reliefs.

The Tale of Two Stupas: Why Sanchi Survived and Amaravati Was Ruined

One of the most striking comparative case studies in archaeological history is why the Great Stupa at **Sanchi** (near Bhopal, Madhya Pradesh) survived nearly intact, whereas the Great Stupa at **Amaravati** (in Guntur district, Andhra Pradesh) was systematically looted and reduced to a ruined mound:

Comparison Axis	Amaravati Stupa (Ruined)	Sanchi Stupa (Preserved)
Discovery Date	Discovered in 1796 by a local Raja seeking building stones.	Discovered in 1818 by British officer General Taylor.
Early Looting	In 1798, Colin Mackenzie made drawings, but British officials systematically carted away slabs to adorn gardens, private mansions, and museums in Madras, Calcutta, and London.	French and British officers sought permission to take the Eastern Gateway to Paris and London, but local rulers resisted.
Role of Indigenous Rulers	No enlightened local patronage existed; local zamindars burned limestone slabs into lime mortar for buildings.	The Nawab Begums of Bhopal (**Shahjehan Begum** and her successor **Sultan Jehan Begum**) provided funds for preservation, museum construction, and publications.
Archaeological Mindset	19th-century antiquarians believed in collecting original relics for colonial capital museums, stripping monuments of their context.	H.H. Cole (appointed Curator of Ancient Monuments in 1880) championed the policy of **in-situ preservation**: "preserve original works where they stand".
Plaster Cast Compromise	Original masterpieces permanently displaced across the British Museum and Victoria & Albert Museum.	Bhopal Begums satisfied European collectors with carefully crafted, exact plaster-cast replicas, retaining the original stone gateways on site.

6. Sculptural Interpretations and Aniconic Art

Early Buddhist sculptors did not depict the Buddha in human form. Influenced by early aniconic conventions, his spiritual presence and key life milestones were communicated through symbolic motifs:

- **The Empty Seat / Meditative Throne:** Symbolized the supreme meditation (**dhyana**) and spiritual presence of the Buddha under the Bodhi tree.
- **The Pipal Tree (Bodhi Tree):** Symbolized the attainment of supreme enlightenment at Bodh Gaya.
- **The Wheel of Law** (Dharmachakra)**:** Symbolized the first sermon preached at Sarnath.

- **The Stupa:** Symbolized the **Mahaparinibbana** (final departure) at Kusinara.

Non-Buddhist Folk Motifs on the Toranas

The stone gateways of Sanchi feature an astonishing array of non-Buddhist folk motifs, indicating that Buddhist monuments incorporated regional beliefs and festive customs:

- **Shalabhanjika:** A beautiful young woman swinging from the branch of a tree at the edge of the gateway. According to ancient Indian popular folklore, her touch caused trees to burst into flower and bear fruit. Sculptors incorporated her as an auspicious motif of fertility and prosperity.
- **Gajalakshmi:** A celestial female figure flanked by two elephants showering water over her from pots. While later identified with Lakshmi (goddess of good fortune), she is also interpreted by Buddhist scholars as Maya, the mother of the Buddha.
- **Animal Motifs:** Elephants (symbolizing strength and wisdom), horses, monkeys, and mythical horned beasts (**makaras** and **yalis**) carved to animate the sacred perimeter and enchant pilgrims.

7. New Religious Traditions: Mahayana, Bodhisattvas, and Early Temples

Around the 1st century CE, profound transformations swept across Buddhist and Brahmanical religious landscapes.

The Emergence of Mahayana Buddhism

The original teachings of early Buddhism emphasized individual self-reliance, moral discipline, and personal meditation to attain liberation (**nibbana**). Over time, a new devotional theology crystallized:

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Figure 2: Figure 2: Comparative Quadrant Matrix Contrasting Jainism, Theravada (Hinayana), Mahayana Buddhism, and Early Puranic Hinduism.

- **Deification of the Buddha:** The Buddha was no longer viewed merely as a mortal human teacher who had attained enlightenment through self-effort, but as a transcendent, divine cosmic savior who heard prayers and granted grace.
- **The Bodhisattva Cult:** Bodhisattvas were deeply compassionate spiritual beings who had accumulated boundless spiritual merit through virtuous lives. Although capable of entering nirvana, they consciously postponed their own liberation to remain in the cycle of existence, rescuing all suffering living beings.
- **Image Worship:** Sculptors began crafting anthropomorphic stone statues of the Buddha and Bodhisattvas. Two great sculptural schools emerged:
  - **Gandhara School (North-West):** Heavily influenced by Hellenistic Greco-Roman aesthetics; realistic wavy hair, Apollo-like facial features, heavy realistic drapery folds.
  - **Mathura School (Ganga Basin):** Fleshy, energetic indigenous Indian style sculpted in mottled red sandstone; transparent drapery, broad masculine shoulders, serene smiling countenance.
- **Terminology:** Proponents of this new theistic path styled their tradition **Mahayana** ("The Great Vehicle"), while dismissing conservative followers of older traditions as **Hinayana** ("The Lesser Vehicle"), who preferred the title **Theravadins** ("Followers of the Path of the Elders").

Puranic Hinduism and the Growth of Temple Architecture

Simultaneously, Brahmanical traditions underwent an internal revolution through the growth of **Bhakti** (loving, personalized devotion to a chosen deity):

- **Vaishnavism:** Centered on the worship of Vishnu as the supreme deity. Developed the doctrine of **Avatars** (ten incarnations), where Vishnu descends to earth in animal or human

form (Matsya, Kurma, Varaha, Narasimha, Vamana, Parashurama, Rama, Krishna, Buddha, Kalki) to vanquish demonic forces and restore cosmic moral order (**dharma**).

- **Shaivism:** Centered on the worship of Shiva, represented symbolically through the **linga** (aniconic phallic emblem of cosmic fertility) or anthropomorphic statues (such as **Nataraja**, the lord of cosmic dance).
- **The Puranas:** Composed in accessible, simple Sanskrit couplets by Brahmanas, the Puranas were meant to be heard by all people—including women and Shudras who were barred from reading the Vedic texts. They integrated local folk deities and regional tribal myths into a unified cosmic pantheon.

Architectural Evolution of Early Structural Temples

Early structural stone temples evolved from primitive shrines into monumental stone complexes:

1. **Garbhagriha ("Womb-house"):** A small, dark, square stone chamber housing the primary idol or linga. It had a single doorway through which the worshipper entered to offer worship and make eye contact (**darshana**) with the deity.
2. **Shikhara ("Mountain Peak"):** A tall towering stone spire built directly above the Garbhagriha in later centuries, symbolizing Mount Meru (the sacred cosmic mountain axis).
3. **Mandapa:** A pillared assembly hall constructed in front of the Garbhagriha where devotees gathered for congregational prayer, sacred dances, and recitations.
4. **Rock-Cut Monolithic Feats:** Along with structural brick and stone temples, rock-cut architecture reached breathtaking heights. The most astonishing masterpiece is the **Kailashnatha Temple at Ellora** (Cave 16, Maharashtra, 8th century CE), carved top-to-bottom out of a single monolithic basalt hillside under Rashtrakuta patronage.



Figure 3: Figure 3: Comprehensive Topic Map & Architectural Framework of Cultural Developments (c. 600 BCE – 600 CE).

High-Yield CUET UG Exam MCQs

Q1. Which of the following rulers of Bhopal provided financial grants, funded the construction of a museum and guest house, and funded the publication of John Marshall's volumes on the Great Stupa at Sanchi?

(A) Begum Rokeya Sakhawat Hossain
(B) Sultan Jehan Begum and Shahjehan Begum
(C) Qudsia Begum and Chand Bibi
(D) Sikandar Begum and Razia Sultan

Q2. In the architectural anatomy of a classical Buddhist stupa, what is the square balcony-like structure perched directly above the hemispherical mound (Anda) called?

(A) Yashti
(B) Chhatri
(C) Harmika
(D) Vedika

Q3. Consider the following statements regarding the core teachings of Jain philosophy:

1. The entire world is animated; even rocks, stones, and water possess living souls (jiva).
2. Severe penance and self-mortification are essential to free the soul from the binding cycles of karma.
3. Mahavira was the original founder and first Tirthankara of the Jain tradition.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

(A) 1 and 2 only
(B) 2 and 3 only
(C) 1 and 3 only
(D) 1, 2, and 3

Q4. Who was the first woman to be ordained as a bhikkhuni (nun) in the Buddhist monastic order (Sangha)?

(A) Yashodhara
(B) Amrapali
(C) Mahapajapati Gotami
(D) Prabhavati Gupta

Q5. Which basket of the Pali Tripitaka specifically contains the rules and regulations governing the monastic discipline and conduct of monks and nuns in the Sangha?

(A) Sutta Pitaka
(B) Vinaya Pitaka
(C) Abhidhamma Pitaka
(D) Dipavamsa

Q6. Why did the Great Stupa at Amaravati suffer destruction while the Great Stupa at Sanchi survived almost completely intact?

(A) Sanchi was protected by the Mauryan army until modern times
(B) Amaravati was built of perishable clay while Sanchi was granite
(C) Amaravati's slabs were carted away before preservation laws existed, while Sanchi benefited from in-situ preservation and Bhopal patronage
(D) Amaravati was entirely obliterated by a massive earthquake

Q7. In early Buddhist sculptural art at Sanchi, the carving of a woman swinging from a tree (Shalabhanjika) on the gateway architrave represents:

(A) Maya giving birth to Siddhartha in the Lumbini grove
(B) An auspicious folk motif representing fertility and tree blossom
(C) A demoness sent by Mara to distract the meditating Buddha
(D) The goddess Lakshmi receiving water from celestial elephants

Q8. Which of the following heterodox philosophical traditions in ancient India was led by Makkhali Gosala and believed that human destiny is entirely governed by predetermined cosmic fate (Niyati)?

(A) Lokayatas
(B) Charvakas
(C) Ajivikas
(D) Samkhyas

Q9. What is the literal meaning of the Buddhist concept Anatta?

(A) Universal sorrow and suffering
(B) The constant impermanence of the physical world
(C) The absence of an eternal, unchanging soul or self
(D) The extinction of individual ego and craving

Q10. Which Buddhist text contains an extraordinary anthology of verses composed by senior nuns (theris) describing their spiritual liberation?

(A) Mahavamsa
(B) Therigatha
(C) Ashokavadana
(D) Milindapanho

Q11. Under which Buddhist tradition did the cult of worshipping Bodhisattvas and anthropomorphic statues of the Buddha with elaborate devotional rituals first become prominent?

(A) Theravada
(B) Hinayana
(C) Mahayana
(D) Vajrayana

Q12. In early structural Hindu temple architecture, what was the small, square, windowless room where the principal deity was installed called?

(A) Mandapa
(B) Shikhara
(C) Garbhagriha
(D) Antarala

Q13. The magnificent rock-cut Kailashnatha Temple at Ellora (Cave 16), carved entirely top-to-bottom from a single monolithic living rock, was built under the patronage of which dynasty?

(A) Guptas
(B) Rashtrakutas
(C) Cholas
(D) Satavahanas

Q14. Which of the following is NOT one of the Five Great Vows (Mahavratas) taken by Jain monks and nuns?

(A) Abstaining from killing (Ahimsa)
(B) Abstaining from falsehood (Satya)
(C) Offering animal sacrifices in Vedic yajnas
(D) Abstaining from possessing property (Aparigraha)

Q15. Which British archaeologist championed the policy of in-situ preservation in 1880, arguing that original works of art should not be stripped from monuments to fill capital museums?

(A) Alexander Cunningham
(B) H.H. Cole
(C) John Marshall
(D) Colin Mackenzie

Solutions & Detailed Explanations

Sol. Q1. Both Shahjehan Begum and her successor Sultan Jehan Begum, rulers of Bhopal, provided substantial funds for the preservation of Sanchi, constructed a museum and guest house for John Marshall, and funded the multi-volume scholarly publications on the stupa.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. The **Harmika** was a balcony-like structure located above the Anda that represented the abode of the gods (**devaloka**). From the Harmika arose the central mast called the **Yashti**, which was crowned by triple umbrellas called the **Chhatri**.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q3. Statements 1 and 2 are core tenets of Jainism. Statement 3 is incorrect because Mahavira was the 24th Tirthankara; the first Tirthankara was Rishabhanatha (Adinatha).

Answer: (A)

Sol. Q4. Mahapajapati Gotami, the Buddha's foster mother and maternal aunt, was the first woman admitted into the Buddhist Sangha after Ananda persuaded the Buddha to allow women monastic ordination.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q5. The **Vinaya Pitaka** contains rules and regulations for monks and nuns; the **Sutta Pitaka** contains the Buddha's discourses and sermons; the **Abhidhamma Pitaka** deals with philosophical matters.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q6. Amaravati was discovered in 1796 and stripped of its carved limestone slabs by colonial officers and local rajas. Sanchi was preserved in-situ due to enlightened patronage

by the Begums of Bhopal and late 19th-century colonial policies championed by H.H. Cole forbidding the removal of original art.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. The **Shalabhanjika** motif in popular folklore represented an auspicious woman whose touch caused trees to flower and bear fruit. Buddhist sculptors incorporated this popular auspicious symbol into the torana architecture.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The **Ajivikas**, led by Makkhali Gosala, were fatalists who believed that human actions, karma, or penance could not alter predetermined fate (**Niyati**).

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. Anatta (Pali) means soullessness or non-self—the doctrine that there is no unchanging, permanent soul or essence in living beings. **Anicca** means impermanence; **Dukkha** means suffering; **Nibbana** means extinction of desire.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. Therigatha is an extraordinary Pali anthology of songs and poems composed by elder Buddhist nuns (**theris**) included within the Khuddaka Nikaya, detailing their spiritual attainment and freedom.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q11. Under **Mahayana** ("The Great Vehicle"), the Buddha was elevated to a divine savior, human statues were sculpted and worshipped, and the cult of compassionate Bodhisattvas flourished.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q12. The **Garbhagriha** ("womb-room") was the core inner sanctuary of an early temple where the principal image or linga was housed. The **Shikhara** was the tall tower built above it, and the **Mandapa** was the pillared entrance hall.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q13. The monolithic Kailashnatha temple at Ellora was carved out of basalt rock during the 8th century CE under the patronage of the **Rashtrakuta** king Krishna I.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q14. Jainism strictly opposed all Vedic animal sacrifices. The five vows are Ahimsa (non-killing), Satya (truthfulness), Asteya (non-stealing), Brahmacharya (celibacy), and Aparigraha (non-possession).

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q15. Major H.H. Cole, appointed Curator of Ancient Monuments in 1880, firmly declared that it was a suicidal mistake to denude country monuments of their original carvings to enrich museums in London or Calcutta, establishing the principle of in-situ conservation.

Answer: (B)

Wrong-Answer Clinic: Common CUET Traps

Common Mistake	Flawed Reasoning	Accurate Historical Fact
Confusing **Anda** with **Harmika**	Assuming Harmika is the dome because it crowns the structure.	**Anda** is the hemispherical earthen dome itself; the **Harmika** is the balcony-like square railing perched atop the Anda representing the abode of gods.
Assuming Mahavira founded Jainism	Treating Mahavira identically to Buddha as a single unique founder.	Mahavira was the **24th Tirthankara**. Jain tradition recognizes 23 prior teachers, beginning with Rishabhanatha and Parshvanatha.
Believing Sanchi stupa was made of marble	Confusing Sanchi's sandstone gateways with Amaravati's white limestone.	Sanchi's dome and gateways were carved from local **sandstone**; Amaravati was built using white and greenish **limestone** carvings.
Misidentifying **Sutta Pitaka** with **Vinaya Pitaka**	Thinking Sutta contains rules because discourses contain advice.	**Vinaya Pitaka** strictly governs monastic rules and disciplinary penalties; **Sutta Pitaka** contains the philosophical dialogues and sermons of the Buddha.
Assuming Hinayana worshipped Buddha statues	Assuming all Buddhists worship statues identically.	Early Theravada (Hinayana) was strictly **aniconic**, using symbols (footprints, wheel, throne). Sculpted statues of the Buddha emerged with **Mahayana**.